Session 6 — The Claude ecosystem: connectors, skills and agents

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Today, without code

Five stops, one running example: finding an apartment near BU.

1. **A connector:** Claude looks up real apartment listings on Zillow.
2. **A skill we build together:** one text file that tells Claude how to hunt for apartments.
3. **Agent apps:** Cowork (paid, by Anthropic) and OpenWork (free) do the same task side by side.
4. **Claude Code:** the same ideas, working inside a project folder.
5. **Scheduled tasks:** work that runs on its own at a set time, and who answers for it.

Demo: a connector — Zillow

STEPS IN CLAUDE

1. Open Customize, then Connectors.
2. Find Zillow. It is built in and made by Zillow.
3. Switch it on for this chat.
4. **Ask: “Show me apartments for rent near Boston University under $2,400 a month.”**

Sources: zillow.com/connect-claude-to-zillow; claude.com/marketplace/connectors/zillow.

Let's build one: an apartment-hunting skill

(a) What must it ask before searching?

The area, the most you can pay per month, how many bedrooms, and the move-in month.

(b) Which connector does it use?

Zillow.

(c) What should it think about before answering?

Fees that push the rent over budget, listings with no photos or "call for price", and how far each one is from campus.

(d) What should every answer look like?

The same short table every time, best first, then one pick.

(e) What must it never do?

Contact landlords, apply for a place, or share your personal details.

(f) What example do we give it?

One example request and one example row of the answer.

OPTIONAL

Optional: a connector that can spend money — MentorCruise

ADD IT AS A CUSTOM CONNECTOR

https://mentorcruise.com/mcp

WORKS WITHOUT A LOGIN

Searching for mentors and reading their profiles.

Question: which tool would you never let it call without asking you?

Source: the tool list served by mentorcruise.com/mcp, retrieved 25 Oct 2026 (each paying tool's description says it needs a signed-in account).

Agent apps: Cowork vs OpenWork

COWORK

Paid, made by Anthropic

- Needs a paid Claude plan (Pro or higher).
- Works in the folders you connect, with your skills and connectors.

OPENWORK

Free and open source

- Can run a free model, such as Llama through Groq's free tier.
- Reads the same SKILL.md files and supports MCP.
- A desktop app for Mac, Windows and Linux.

Live: the same skill and the same task, side by side.

Sources: claude.com/pricing; github.com/different-ai/openwork (README: "the free, open-source alternative to Claude Cowork"; MIT outside its team features) — checked 25 Oct 2026.

Claude Code or Cowork?

Is the output code that lives in a repo and must be run, tested and versioned?

YES → Claude Code
because code needs git, tests and a terminal

NO → Cowork
docs, sheets, decks, research — works only in folders you connect

	Claude Code	Cowork
Who it's for	People who build software	Knowledge workers — no terminal needed
Works on	A code repository (a folder under git)	Folders you connect, your apps, the browser
Interface	Terminal, VS Code, desktop app, web	The Claude app (desktop for your own files)
Typical tasks	Build a feature, fix a bug, run tests, open a PR	Organize files, build sheets and decks, research
Your world	Add a feature to your team's Streamlit app	Turn a folder of receipts into an expense sheet

Both need a paid Claude plan (Pro or higher); neither is on Free. Sources: claude.com/pricing; support.claude.com "Get started with Cowork"; code.claude.com/docs — checked 25 Oct 2026.

Demo: Claude Code

START

`/init` creates a starter CLAUDE.md guide for the project.

`/plan` switches to plan mode: Claude proposes changes before it edits. You can pass a task, such as “/plan add a search box”.

KEEP THE CONTEXT UNDER CONTROL

`/context` shows what is filling the context window, as a coloured grid, with suggestions.

`/compact` frees space by summarizing the conversation so far; say what to keep: “/compact keep the decisions about the data”.

`/clear` starts a fresh conversation; the project memory in CLAUDE.md stays.

`/rewind` rolls the code and the conversation back to an earlier point.

WATCH THE WORK AND THE BILL

Subagents: there is no /subtask command. Ask in plain words to “use a subagent” for a side job, such as research.

`/tasks` shows background work, including subagents that finished.

`/usage` shows the session’s cost, your plan’s usage limits and activity stats. /cost and /stats open the same view.

Then: add GitHub’s MCP server, then ask Claude Code to file an issue

Source: code.claude.com/docs/en/commands — checked 25 Oct 2026.

Scheduled tasks — discussion

You can schedule a task: give Claude a job and a time, and it runs on its own.

It runs on your own computer. Your computer acts as the server, so it has to be on, awake and running the Claude app. If it is asleep at that time, the task runs once when the computer wakes up.

Sources: support.claude.com (Cowork scheduled tasks) · code.claude.com/docs/en/desktop-scheduled-tasks — checked 25 Oct 2026.